

archaic per share value below which a company promised not to issue shares—that, “When share values drop, the prices for some shares fall more than the circumstances really warrant and in these instances there may exist a good chance to make a profitable investment.”⁴ It provided a list of 33 issues below par, and recommended the “Hauraki Whaling Company.”⁵ While *New Zealand Stocks and Shares* had only five subscribers, Brierley decided to print 1,000 copies. He reasoned that every listed company in New Zealand would want a copy, and, after six months when no doubt they would have grown attached to the newsletter he could invoice them for the back copies. Brierley found that about one in four paid up. He wrote back to those who didn’t pay, noting that “National Investments”—the grandiose name under which he published the newsletter—was “disappointed” that they had decided not to pay, and sought the full amount for the back issues. Those who refused again received a further letter from the 19-year-old Brierley that began, “We are disappointed in view of the fact that we are writing an article on your organization.”⁶ Very few resisted further.

By the 1960s *New Zealand Stocks and Shares* was no longer an amateurish, six-page newsletter with five subscribers, but a well known, if slightly outré, publication in New Zealand.⁷ Brierley was unrestrained by any sense of propriety, and often harshly criticized management, employing a sarcastic tone to goad them into returning capital to shareholders. Brierley said, “I was conscious of the fact that if one wrote offensive untruths it would be possible to be sued for large sums of money, so one tried to write offensive truths. Really, what seemed offensive in those days is now innocuous.” Still, it was unheard of in New Zealand’s establishment business circles at the time. Some wit declared the publication was less *Stocks and Shares*, and more “Shocks and Stares.”⁸ As he had researched listed companies in New Zealand, Brierley had been struck by the number dominated by elderly, entrenched board members who sat on underperforming assets and retained earnings with a death grip, refusing to pay dividends. Many of the businesses had outlived their useful lives, but the companies that owned them were overcapitalized, with passive shareholders who allowed the business to drift along. Brierley imagined “aging directors, dozy and distant in the wood-paneled dimness of their boardrooms, recovering from a heavy luncheon at the club. Goodness knows, there was no need for them to be on full alert. It was their game and generally they found everyone played fair.”⁹ He decided to shake it up.

Brierley had some experience agitating at companies. He had published in *Stocks and Shares* a series of articles written in his usual sardonic manner about an offer for Wellington Loan and Investment Company Limited. When a second offer emerged that pushed up the price, a local newspaper credited Brierley with the increase. He used the publicity to launch R. A.